

The Question Behind the Question

Difficult interview prompts are often requests for evidence, judgment or self-awareness.

THE DECISION

When a question feels confrontational, pause long enough to identify the capability being tested. “Tell me about a failure” may be a request to understand ownership, learning and decision quality rather than an invitation to perform regret.

THREE MOVES

→ Name the likely capability before answering: judgment, influence, resilience, prioritisation or technical depth.

→ Choose one real example that shows appropriate stakes; avoid a story so small that it reveals nothing or so sensitive that it creates unnecessary risk.

→ End with a clear result or reflection tied back to the role you want.

TRY THIS BEFORE YOUR NEXT STEP

Take one difficult question you expect. Write: “They may be trying to understand whether I can...” and complete the sentence before choosing a story.

Reading note: This is a sample briefing for educational reading. It is not a historic newsletter send and does not guarantee an interview, offer or outcome. Framework reference: [University of Michigan Career Center — Interviewing Resources](#).